

24-Week Half Ironman (70.3) Training Plan

Beginner to Half Ironman Ready

Race Distance: 1.9km Swim | 90km Bike | 21.1km Run

Target Audience: Beginners or those with sprint triathlon experience

Weekly Training: 4-6 days per week | 5-10 hours total

Program Structure: 6 phases over 24 weeks

Program Overview

This comprehensive 24-week program takes you from beginner fitness to half ironman ready. The plan uses periodization principles with progressive phases: Base Building → Aerobic Development → Build Phase → Peak Phase → Race Simulation → Taper & Race.

Key Principles:

- Gradual volume progression (10% increase per week max)
 - Recovery weeks every 3-4 weeks
 - Long course simulation in final 8 weeks
 - Brick workouts to practice transitions
 - Nutrition practice during long sessions
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PHASE 1: BASE BUILDING (Weeks 1-4)

Week 1: Assessment Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim Assessment (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5-10 min easy swim
- Main Set: Swim 20 min continuous (take breaks if needed)
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim
- *Record distance for baseline*

Wednesday: Easy Bike (45 min)

- Entire session easy/conversational pace
- High cadence (90+ RPM)

Thursday: Run Assessment (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: Run/walk 30 min continuous
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk
- *Record distance for baseline*

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

- Swim easy, focus on form

Saturday: Bike Assessment (60 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy
- Main Set: Bike 45 min continuous
- Cool-down: 5 min easy
- *Record distance for baseline*

Sunday: Easy Run (30 min)

- Run/walk easy (conversational pace)

Weekly Volume: ~4.5 hours

Week 2-3: Base Building

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 6 x 3 min easy with 1 min recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (45 min)

Thursday: Run (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: Run/walk 30 min easy
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Long Bike (75-90 min)

- Entire session easy/conversational pace
- *This is your first “long” session*
- Practice nutrition: have a sports drink or energy bar at 45 min mark

Sunday: Easy Run (30 min)

Weekly Volume: ~5 hours

Week 4: Recovery Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Bike (45 min)

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Run (30 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2 hours

PHASE 2: AEROBIC DEVELOPMENT (Weeks 5-8)

Week 5-6: Aerobic Building

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 8 x 3 min easy with 1 min recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (50 min)

Thursday: Run (50 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: Run/walk 35 min easy
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Long Bike (100-120 min)

- Entire session easy/conversational pace
- Practice nutrition every 45 min
- *Building aerobic capacity*

Sunday: Easy Run (35 min)

Weekly Volume: ~5.5 hours

Week 7: Build Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim (40 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 10 x 3 min easy with 1 min recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (50 min)

Thursday: Run (55 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: Run/walk 40 min easy
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Long Bike (120 min)

- Warm-up: 15 min easy
- Main Set: 90 min easy/conversational
- Cool-down: 15 min easy
- *Approaching half race bike distance*

Sunday: Easy Run (40 min)

Weekly Volume: ~6 hours

Week 8: Recovery Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Bike (45 min)

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Run (30 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2 hours

PHASE 3: BUILD PHASE (Weeks 9-12)

Week 9-10: Intensity Introduction

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim Intervals (40 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 6 x 4 min at test pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (50 min)

Thursday: Run Intervals (55 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 5 x 5 min at test pace with 2 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Long Bike (130 min)

- Warm-up: 15 min easy

- Main Set: 100 min easy/conversational
- Cool-down: 15 min easy

Sunday: Easy Run (45 min)

Weekly Volume: ~6.5 hours

Week 11: Build Week with Brick

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim Intervals (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 8 x 4 min at test pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (50 min)

Thursday: Run Intervals (60 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 6 x 5 min at test pace with 2 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Bike + Run Brick (120 min)

- Bike: 15 min warm-up, 75 min easy, 10 min cool-down
- Transition: 3-5 min
- Run: 15 min easy into race pace
- *Critical for learning race-day transitions*

Sunday: Easy Run (45 min)

Weekly Volume: ~7 hours

Week 12: Recovery Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Bike (45 min)

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Run (30 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2 hours

PHASE 4: PEAK PHASE (Weeks 13-16)

Week 13-14: Peak Building

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim Intervals (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 8 x 5 min at test pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (50 min)

Thursday: Run Intervals (65 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 6 x 6 min at test pace with 2 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Long Bike (150 min)

- Warm-up: 15 min easy
- Main Set: 120 min easy/conversational (near race distance)
- Cool-down: 15 min easy
- *Practice race-day nutrition every 45 min*

Sunday: Long Run (60 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 45 min easy/conversational
- Cool-down: 5 min easy walk
- *Approaching half race run distance*

Weekly Volume: ~8 hours

Week 15: Peak Week with Simulation

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim Intervals (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 10 x 4 min at test pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (50 min)

Thursday: Run Intervals (65 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 8 x 5 min at test pace with 1.5 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Bike + Run Brick (150 min)

- Bike: 15 min warm-up, 100 min at race pace, 10 min cool-down
- Transition: 3-5 min
- Run: 20 min easy into race pace
- *This is your final hard effort before taper*

Sunday: Easy Run (45 min)

Weekly Volume: ~8.5 hours

Week 16: Recovery Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Bike (45 min)

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Run (30 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2 hours

PHASE 5: RACE SIMULATION (Weeks 17-20)

Week 17-18: Race Simulation

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim (40 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 6 x 5 min at race pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (50 min)

Thursday: Run (60 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 5 x 6 min at race pace with 2 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Full Triathlon Simulation (180 min)

- Swim: 30 min easy (simulating 1.9km)
- Transition: 5 min
- Bike: 90 min easy (simulating 90km)
- Transition: 5 min
- Run: 30 min easy (simulating 21.1km)
- *This is your dress rehearsal - practice everything*

Sunday: Easy Run (45 min)

Weekly Volume: ~8 hours

Week 19: Peak Simulation

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim (45 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 8 x 5 min at race pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (50 min)

Thursday: Run (65 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog

- Main Set: 6 x 6 min at race pace with 1.5 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

Friday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Saturday: Bike + Run Brick (150 min)

- Bike: 15 min warm-up, 100 min at race pace, 10 min cool-down
- Transition: 5 min
- Run: 20 min easy into race pace

Sunday: Easy Run (50 min)

Weekly Volume: ~8.5 hours

Week 20: Recovery Week

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Bike (45 min)

Friday: Rest day

Saturday: Easy Run (30 min)

Sunday: Rest day

Weekly Volume: ~2 hours

PHASE 6: TAPER & RACE (Weeks 21-24)

Week 21: Begin Taper

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim (35 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 6 x 3 min at race pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (40 min)

Thursday: Run (45 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 4 x 4 min at race pace with 2 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

Friday: Easy Swim (15 min)

Saturday: Easy Bike (40 min)

Sunday: Easy Run (30 min)

Weekly Volume: ~4 hours

Week 22: Taper Continues

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Swim (30 min)

- Warm-up: 5 min easy swim
- Main Set: 4 x 3 min at race pace with 1 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 5 min easy swim

Wednesday: Easy Bike (35 min)

Thursday: Run (40 min)

- Warm-up: 10 min easy walk/jog
- Main Set: 3 x 3 min at race pace with 2 min easy recovery
- Cool-down: 8 min easy walk/jog

Friday: Easy Swim (15 min)

Saturday: Rest day

Sunday: Easy Run (25 min)

Weekly Volume: ~3 hours

Week 23: Final Taper

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Swim (20 min)

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Bike (30 min)

Friday: Easy Swim (15 min)

Saturday: Rest day

Sunday: Easy Run (20 min)

Weekly Volume: ~1.5 hours

Week 24: RACE WEEK

Monday: Rest day

Tuesday: Easy Swim (15 min)

- Very easy, confidence-building

Wednesday: Rest day

Thursday: Easy Bike (20 min)

- Very easy, just moving

Friday: Rest day - Final preparations

- Lay out all gear

- Review race plan
- Eat familiar foods

Saturday: Rest day - Race day prep

- Light walk or easy swim if you need to move
- Hydrate well
- Early bed time

Sunday: RACE DAY!

- Arrive 1-2 hours early
- Warm up gently
- Review your race plan
- Trust your 24 weeks of training
- Have fun and celebrate!

Weekly Volume: ~0.5 hours

Race-Day Nutrition Strategy

2-3 Hours Before Race:

- Familiar breakfast: oatmeal with banana and honey, or toast with jam
- Hydrate with water and electrolytes

30 Min Before Race:

- Light snack: banana or energy bar
- Final hydration

During Swim:

- Focus on pacing and breathing
- No nutrition needed (too short)

Bike (90 km, ~3-4 hours):

- Start nutrition at 45 min mark
- Every 45 min: 1 energy bar or 2 energy gels
- Every 30 min: 500ml sports drink or water with electrolytes
- Aim for 200-300 calories per hour

Run (21.1 km, ~2-3 hours):

- Start nutrition at 15 min mark
- Every 20 min: 1 energy gel or sports drink
- Walk through aid stations if needed
- Focus on hydration - drink at every station

Post-Race:

- Within 30 min: Protein + carbs (chocolate milk, recovery drink, sandwich)
 - Rehydrate with electrolytes
 - Rest and celebrate!
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Training Terminology

Test Pace: The pace you can sustain for 5-10 minutes of hard effort.

Race Pace: The pace you plan to hold during the actual race.

Easy/Conversational Pace: You should be able to speak in full sentences.

Warm-up (WU): Gradually increase heart rate before main set.

Main Set (MS): The primary focus of the workout.

Cool-down (CD): Gradually decrease intensity to aid recovery.

Recovery Interval (RI): Easy effort between hard efforts.

Recovery & Injury Prevention

Sleep: Aim for 7-9 hours per night. This is when adaptation happens.

Stretching: 10-15 min after each workout, especially legs and shoulders.

Foam Rolling: 5-10 min on rest days for muscle recovery.

Massage: Monthly professional massage or self-massage with foam roller.

Nutrition: Eat protein + carbs within 30 min of every workout.

Listen to Your Body: If something hurts (not just tired), take an extra rest day.

Cross-Training: Optional easy yoga or swimming on rest days.

Race Week Checklist

- ☐ Lay out all gear the night before
 - ☐ Check weather forecast
 - ☐ Review race course map
 - ☐ Plan parking and arrival time
 - ☐ Practice race-day breakfast
 - ☐ Get good sleep 2-3 nights before
 - ☐ Reduce training volume by 70%
 - ☐ Maintain intensity but reduce duration
 - ☐ Eat familiar foods only
 - ☐ Hydrate consistently
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Post-Race

Congratulations on completing your first half ironman! Now:

- Rest for 5-7 days with easy movement only

- Reflect on what went well and what to improve
 - Consider your next goal (another 70.3, full ironman, or new distance)
 - Celebrate your amazing achievement!
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Remember: This is YOUR training plan. Adjust rest days as needed to fit your life. Consistency beats perfection. Trust the process!